

Case File: The Saturday Alibi

Investigator _____ Squad _____ Date _____

1 What is digital forensics?

~3 min

Digital forensics is the science of finding facts on phones, computers, and drives — then proving them. A good investigator never trusts one clue. They collect several pieces of evidence and check whether the story holds together.

Metadata — hidden data *about* a file: when a photo was taken, and the GPS location where the phone was.

Timeline — putting events in time order to see what really happened, and when.

Deleted ≠ gone — "deleted" files often sit in a *Recently Deleted* folder and can be recovered.

Corroboration — when two or more clues point to the same fact, you can trust it.

Q1. In your own words, why shouldn't an investigator trust a single screenshot or one photo by itself?

2 Your assignment

~2 min

CASE BRIEF

Dana Brisco, a clerk at Hartwell Hardware in the town of Brindle Falls, called in **sick last Saturday**. Their manager suspects Dana faked it to attend the sold-out **Aurora Static** concert. Dana handed over their phone to clear their name. **Your job:** examine the phone and decide — does the alibi hold up?

HOW TO WORK

Open **every** app on the phone — Messages, Phone, Photos, Browser, and Notes — and check each **Recently Deleted** folder. Don't stop at the first thing you find. Record what you see in the evidence log on the next page.

Q2. Before you start: what would Dana's phone look like if they *really* were home sick all day? Write one prediction.

3 Evidence log — search the phone

~9 min

For each app, write the **one clue** that matters most and the **time** attached to it. Tip: in Photos, open a picture and read its *EXIF metadata* for the location.

APP	WHAT DID YOU FIND? (THE KEY CLUE)	TIME / DATE
 Photos		
 Photos — Deleted		
 Messages		
 Phone (Calls)		
 Browser		
 Notes		

4 Connect the clues

~4 min

Q3. A photo's metadata shows *where* the phone was. Which photo places Dana somewhere other than home on Saturday night — and what's the location?

Q4. The call log shows the sick-day call. Who did Dana call on Saturday morning, and at what time?

Q5. Find one message or note that proves the sick day was *planned in advance*. Quote it.

Q6. Something was deleted from the phone. What was it, and why do you think Dana deleted it?

5 Build the timeline

~2 min

Put your three strongest clues in time order.

TIME	WHAT HAPPENED (AND WHICH APP PROVES IT)

6 Your verdict

~2 min

Does Dana's alibi hold up?

☐ The alibi HOLDS (Dana was sick) ☐ The alibi FAILS (Dana faked it)

Back up your verdict with evidence from at least three different apps (remember: corroboration!).

Q7. Reflection: what is one thing this case taught you about how investigators find the truth?
